> Restaurants and small retailers experienced steep drops in revenue during the pandemic**;** **however**, many survived the downturn.

Complex Sentences

A **complex sentence** contains one main clause (a clause that contains a subject and a predicate and can stand alone as a sentence) and one or more subordinate clauses (also known as dependent clauses). **Subordinate clauses** begin with a subordinating word or phrase such as *although, because, even if, when, whenever, since, as though, whether, as long as, until,* or *while*. The main clause expresses the main idea of the sentence, and the subordinate clause expresses the less important idea. Like a main clause, a subordinate clause has a subject and verb; however, unlike a main clause, it cannot stand alone as a sentence. A subordinate clause punctuated as a sentence is a type of sentence fragment. The subordinate clauses in the following sentences are underlined.

> Although the federal government provided financial assistance, the money came too late for many businesses. When schools and universities shut down in March of 2020, students had to learn at home, a situation that proved challenging for many households.

Compound-Complex Sentences

A **compound-complex sentence** contains two or more main clauses (clauses that contain subjects and predicates and can stand alone as sentences) and one or more subordinate clauses (clauses that begin with a subordinating word such as *although, because, even if, when, whenever, since, as though, whether, as long as, until,* and *while*). A compound-complex sentence is an effective structure to use when you want to express three or more ideas in a single sentence. The example sentence has two main clauses (double underline) and three subordinate clauses (single underline).

> When school districts reopened, parents had to decide whether they wanted their children to attend classes in person, and they had to be ready for classes to move online if there were outbreaks of the coronavirus in their community.

H 4. Sentence Errors

These four common sentence errors can make your writing hard to read: fragments, comma splices, run-on sentences, and mixed constructions.

Sentence Fragments

A **sentence fragment** is a group of words that lacks a subject, a verb, or both, or it is a subordinate clause (a clause that begins with a subordinating word such as *although, because, since,* and so on) punctuated as though it were a sentence by itself. Although most are grammatical errors, sentence fragments can be used judiciously in conventional writing so long as the purpose is clear to readers and the fragment is clearly intended.

Unintentional Sentence Fragments

Often a sentence fragment follows a complete sentence and expands on it, as illustrated in the examples below (fragments are underlined). You can correct most fragment errors by attaching the fragment to the sentence to which it belongs or by rewriting the fragment as a complete sentence.

> **Sentence Fragment** People think that they will be happy if they are well off. That money will make everything better.
>
> **Revised by Attaching the Fragment to a Complete Sentence** People think that they will be happy if they are well off and that money will make everything better.
>
> **Sentence Fragment** Psychologist David Myers explains how students have increasingly chosen to attend college to make more money. Thus further explaining his point of people's desire to use money

to gain happiness.

Revised by Attaching the Fragment to a Complete Sentence Psychologist David Myers explains how students have increasingly chosen to attend college to make more money, thus further explaining his point of people's desire to use money to gain happiness.

Sentence Fragment Although income grew, people's happiness did not. With rich people reporting that even though they had plenty of money, their happiness had not changed much.

Revised by Adding a Verb Although income grew, people's happiness did not. Rich people reported that even though they had plenty of money, their happiness had not changed much.

Sentence Fragment For many people, increased income is being spent on the things that people are unable to pay less for. Things like taxes, childcare, transportation, and housing.

Revised by Adding a Subject and a Verb For many people, increased income is being spent on things that people are unable to pay less for. These include taxes, childcare, transportation, and housing.

Intentional Sentence Fragments

Intentional sentence fragments force quick reading, inviting readers to stitch meaning to together. Intentional fragments are most common in creative writing and advertising.

The rabbit darted out of the shadows. A flash of movement. The dog lunged and strained at the leash.

Comma Splices

A **comma splice** is a common error that occurs when two complete sentences are joined by a comma. You can correct a comma splice by adding a coordinating conjunction (*for, and, nor, but, or, yet,* or *so),* adding a period and creating two sentences, adding a coordinating conjunction and creating a compound sentence, or subordinating one clause and creating a complex sentence.

Comma Splice The author sheds light on the financial sacrifice many mothers make**,** they take care of their children without compensation and often lose professional status.

Revised with a Coordinating Conjunction The author sheds light on the financial sacrifice many mothers make, **for** they take care of their children without compensation and often lose professional status.

Comma Splice Many college students see their education as the way to become wealthy**,** some are sacrificing happiness to pursue high-paying careers.

Revised with a Period Many college students see their education as the way to become wealthy**. S**ome are sacrificing happiness to pursue high-paying careers.

Comma Splice Psychologist David Myers conducted multiple surveys asking people about their attitudes about money**,** the results revealed that people felt they needed more regardless of how much they had.

Revised with a Semicolon Psychologist David Myers conducted multiple surveys asking people about their attitudes about money**;** the results revealed that people felt they needed more regardless of how much they had.

Comma Splice Love cannot be paid for**,** it is a gift that parents give because they love their children.

Revised with a Semicolon and Transitional Word or Phrase Love cannot be paid for**; indeed,** it is a gift that parents give because they love their children.

Comma Splice Students are choosing majors to enable them to earn more money**,** they are under the misconception that earning money guarantees happiness.

Revised with a Subordinate Clause Students are choosing majors to enable them to earn more money **because** they are under the misconception that earning money guarantees happiness.

Run-on Sentences

In a **run-on sentence**, two or more complete sentences are not separated by any punctuation. Like comma splices, most run-on sentences can be revised in one or more of the following ways: adding a coordinating conjunction (*for, and, nor, but, or, yet,* or *so*), adding a period and creating two sentences, separating the sentences with a semicolon, separating the sentences with a semicolon and transitional word or phrase (such as *on the other hand, however, consequently,* and so on), or turning the less important sentence into a subordinate clause starting with a subordinating word such as *although, because, if, when, since*, and so on.

Run-on Sentence The DNR eventually designated the area as crucial habitat the protection came too late to save the nesting birds.

Revised with a Comma and a Coordinating Conjunction The DNR eventually designated the area as crucial habitat**, but** the protection came too late to save the nesting birds.

Run-on Sentence Most people realize that being wealthy won't just happen many college students choose a major that will ensure they make money.

Revised with a Period Most people realize that being wealthy won't just happen**.** Many college students choose a major that will ensure they make money.

Run-on Sentence Parents do not expect any financial reward they care for their children out of love and responsibility.

Revised with a Semicolon Parents do not expect any financial reward**;** they care for their children out of love and responsibility.

Run-on Sentence The average American family's expenses have risen faster than incomes they have saved less than prior generations.

Revised with a Semicolon and Transitional Word or Phrase The average American family's expenses have risen faster than incomes**; as a result,** they have saved less than prior generations.

Run-on Sentence College students have the opportunity to choose any major they tend to choose those that offer immediate opportunities to earn money when they graduate.

Revised with a Subordinate Clause **Although** college students have the opportunity to choose any major**,** they tend to choose those that offer immediate opportunities to earn money when they graduate.

Mixed Sentence Constructions

A **mixed sentence** contains parts that do not fit together because of grammar or meaning. In the following example, the writer needs to revise either the second part to fit with the first part or the first part to fit with the second. (See Editing Focus: Mixed Sentence Constructions for more on mixed sentence constructions.)

Mixed Sentence By starting my general studies classes last semester gave me the opportunity to take classes in my major this fall.

Second Part Revised By starting my general studies classes last spring, I had the opportunity to take classes in my major this fall.

First Part Revised Starting my general studies classes last spring gave me the opportunity to take classes in my major this fall.

***Just because . . . doesn't mean* Constructions.** *Just because . . . doesn't mean* constructions are common in

speech but should be avoided in writing.

Just because Just because I want to be a doctor doesn't mean I will get into medical school.

Revised Simply wanting to be a doctor doesn't guarantee admission to medical school.

Revised Although I want to be a doctor, I will need to work hard to get into medical school.

H 5. Words and Language

The English language is rich and always evolving, offering you many ways and words to express yourself in writing and speech.

Language Varieties

English is not one language but many, made up of regional and social dialects. In addition, groups speak using specialized language among themselves that can be difficult for outsiders to understand. As a writer, be aware of the audience for your writing. Use language that your readers will understand directly or from context.

Dialects

English **dialects** are distinctive versions of the language used in geographical regions and/or by particular social or ethnic groups. Standard American English, the English spoken by newscasters, is one such dialect, as are African American Vernacular English, Creole, Appalachian English, and others. English dialects have many features in common, but each has particulars of grammar, vocabulary, and pronunciation. (For an in-depth discussion of dialects and academic writing, see Spotlight on … Variations of English.)

Slang

Groups of people with similar skills and interests often develop **slang** that allows them to express ideas quickly and vividly. Slang also signals knowledge about a particular topic, such as meme culture, music, sports, and more. Slang is generally considered too casual for most academic writing, but it may be appropriate for personal essays. In your papers, be aware of your purpose and audience when choosing to use slang. Avoid using slang that your readers are unlikely to understand.

Technical Expressions

Experts in many professional fields use specialized and technical expressions that allow them to communicate efficiently and clearly with each other. Such language is often incomprehensible for nonexperts and should be avoided in writing for general readers. (For tips on writing about a technical topic for an audience of nonspecialists, see Spotlight on … Discipline-Specific and Technical Language.)

Biased Language

Biased words and expressions exclude or demean people on the basis of gender, sex, sexual orientation, age, ethnicity, social class, or physical or mental traits.

Biased Language Based on Sex and Gender

English includes words and expressions that are considered biased based on sex and gender, such as *mankind, businessman, chairman, fireman,* and so on. These are commonly replaced by gender-neutral words such as *humanity, businessperson, chair* or *chairperson,* and *firefighter.* (See Spotlight on … Bias in Language and Research for more on language bias.)

In addition, the English pronoun *he* has traditionally been used as the gender-neutral pronoun. For example, the construction *A doctor should have a caring attitude toward his patients* was once common but is now widely viewed as gender biased because many doctors are not men. For a discussion of the pronoun *he* used as the gender-neutral pronoun, see Pronouns.